

Food-related anxiety

When eating becomes stressful — understanding why, and finding a calmer relationship with food.

When food has been followed by pain, nausea or urgency, it's completely understandable to become anxious about eating. The body learns to associate meals with threat, and mealtimes can start to feel like a risk rather than a pleasure.

The narrowing trap

- 1 A food seems to trigger symptoms, so you **avoid** it
- 2 The list of "safe" foods slowly **shrinks**
- 3 Eating becomes more **anxious** and less flexible
- 4 Anxiety itself raises gut sensitivity — which can trigger more symptoms

Over time, restriction can affect nutrition, energy and social life — and, because anxiety amplifies gut signals, it can make symptoms worse rather than better.

First steps toward ease

- ☐ **Regulate before you eat.** A few slow breaths settle the system so the gut isn't already braced.
- ☐ **Curiosity, not control.** Notice what happens without judging it — patterns are information, not verdicts.
- ☐ **Reintroduce gradually.** With support, gently widen your range rather than eliminating more.
- ☐ **Work as a team.** A dietitian and your medical team can guide safe, structured changes.

When to seek more support

If you're losing weight, eating a very restricted range, or feeling frightened around most foods, please speak with your GP or specialist. Food anxiety is common and treatable — you don't have to manage it alone.

The goal isn't a perfect diet. It's a calmer, more flexible relationship with eating, rebuilt one steady step at a time.

This sheet is general information — not a diagnosis or a substitute for medical care. EF Health psychological support works alongside your medical team, never instead of it. If your symptoms are new, severe, or changing, please speak with your GP or specialist.

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